



RETAIL NEWS & VIEWS

www.retailstat.com

Financial Health Insights Newsletter



July 29, 2025



MASS MERCHANDISERS



Walmart has launched new AI "Super Agents" to assist store associates with customer-service tasks and inventory management. The tools, including Digital Teammate, Digital Inventory Analyst, and Digital Point of Sale Specialist, are accessible through associates' hand-held devices. The initiative follows Walmart's May launch of an AI-powered search experience for customers.



TARGET

Target is ending its long-standing price match policy, a move that could give pricing advantages to competitors like Amazon and Walmart. The retailer has quietly updated its website to reflect the change, which eliminates both competitor price matching and post-purchase price adjustments. The policy shift comes as Target intensifies focus on its "everyday low price" strategy across essential categories.



GROCERY RETAILERS



Lidl is preparing to open four new stores across the East Coast, with locations in Middletown, Delaware, and Bowie, Maryland, opening July 31, followed by a store in New York City's Lower East Side on August 1. A fourth location in Woodbridge, Virginia, is set to open on August 14.



Loblaw Companies reported Q2 revenue increased 3.5% to \$14.3 billion (Canadian), driven by strong performance in its discount grocery segment. Same-store sales grew 2.2% overall, with the discount division outperforming conventional stores. E-commerce sales grew 15.1%.



Stop & Shop has appointed Bob Yager as executive vice president of operations, effective August 19, 2025. Yager, who most recently served as president of Albertsons' Portland division, will oversee operations for all 380 Stop & Shop stores across the Northeast. The appointment comes amid Stop & Shop's three-year, \$4 billion investment plan to revitalize its stores and streamline its supply chain.

MARKET BASKET

Market Basket has terminated at least four senior executives, including President of Operations David McLean, who had been with the company for 47 years. The terminations follow the board's earlier decision to place CEO Arthur T. Demoulas on administrative leave. The company cited "ongoing operational deficiencies" as the reason for the leadership changes. Market Basket operates 96 stores across Massachusetts, New Hampshire, and Maine.



**HERITAGE
GROCERS
GROUP**

Heritage Grocers Group announced Suzy Monford has stepped down as CEO after leading the company for 16 months. Chief Administrative Officer Ernie Serrano will serve as interim CEO while a search for Monford's replacement is conducted. The Company operates 78 stores across California, Nevada, Arizona, Texas, and Illinois under the Cardenas Markets, El Rancho Supermercado, and Tony's Fresh Market banners.



Asian supermarket chains are accelerating their expansion in Washington state. **T&T Supermarket** opened a 40,000-square-foot store in Bellevue on July 26, while **Hmart** recently opened in Tacoma and announced a new location in Federal Way. **99 Ranch Market** opened a 43,000-square-foot flagship store in downtown Seattle in June, and Lam's Seafood Market is planning a new store in Lynnwood.



FOODSERVICE / WHOLESALERS



Kraft Heinz has announced a partnership with Live Nation to bring its brands to concert venues across North America. The multi-year deal will place Kraft Heinz products, including Heinz Ketchup, Velveeta, Philadelphia, Grey Poupon, and Kraft Mac & Cheese, at Live Nation amphitheaters and festivals. The collaboration includes custom menu items, branded concession stands, and activations at major music festivals.



DEPARTMENT STORES



A portfolio of 119 **JC Penney** stores has been acquired for \$947 million by a partnership between Agree Realty and Blackstone. The acquisition includes JC Penney locations across 37 states, with an average size of 92,000 square feet and average lease term of 13.2 years. The stores were sold by Copper Property CTL Pass Through Trust, which had acquired the properties following JC Penney's 2020 bankruptcy.

Dillard's Dillard's, Inc. announced plans to reincorporate from Delaware to Texas, pending shareholder approval. The Company cited Delaware's 8.7% corporate tax rate, annual franchise fees of up to \$250,000, substantial escheatment liabilities, and increased shareholder litigation exposure as key factors. Texas is Dillard's largest market with 55 stores, and the move is expected to generate administrative and financial efficiencies while preserving shareholder rights.



APPAREL & FOOTWEAR

AMERICAN EAGLE American Eagle Outfitters saw its stock rise 4.5% on July 25 following the release of its fall campaign featuring actress Sydney Sweeney. American Eagle shares are up 94% year-to-date.



Puma shares dropped 18% on July 25 after the Company cut its full-year sales and profit outlook, citing tariff impacts and weak demand in China. The Company now expects 2025 currency-adjusted sales to grow by low-to-mid single-digit percentage, with operating profit projected between €590 million and €670 million.



Tilly's Inc. announced that Nate Smith will become president and chief executive officer effective August 18, 2025. Smith most recently served as president of Carter's U.S. Retail segment and brings over 20 years of retail experience. He will succeed Ed Thomas, who is retiring after serving as Tilly's CEO since 2015.



Temu is in breach of EU rules designed to prevent the sale of illegal products, according to the European Commission. The Commission has given the Chinese e-commerce platform one month to submit a plan to address the shortcomings or face penalties of up to 6% of its global annual turnover.



Deckers' Hoka brand reported Q1 revenue increased 32% year-over-year to \$507 million. The brand opened — BRANDS — its 10th owned retail location in June, with plans to add 5-10 more stores annually over the next few years. Deckers raised its fiscal 2026 outlook, now expecting Hoka to grow in the high teens to low 20% range.



As reported in our July 25 [Alert](#), LVMH is reportedly in advanced discussions to sell its Marc Jacobs fashion brand, with a potential deal value around \$1 billion. The luxury conglomerate is in talks with multiple strategic buyers, including Authentic Brands Group, Bluestar Alliance, and WHP Global. The potential divestiture aligns with LVMH's strategy of pruning non-core assets from its portfolio, following past sales of Donna Karan, DKNY, Off-White, and Stella McCartney.



Kizik Shoes is suing Skechers for patent infringement. Kizik alleges that Sketchers designs infringe on patents related to its Hands Free Slip-ins technology. The lawsuit, filed in the U.S. District Court for the Central District of California, comes as both companies compete in the growing market for convenient, accessible footwear options.



SPORTING GOODS



As reported in our July 25 [Alert](#), **Backcountry** has acquired Utah-based retailer **Level Nine Sports**, adding two retail locations in Millcreek and Ogden to its portfolio. The deal enhances Level Nine Sports' e-commerce capabilities while offering Backcountry customers a broader selection of budget-friendly outdoor gear. Level Nine Sports, known as a value-focused player in Utah's outdoor market, will continue to operate under its own brand with expanded support from Backcountry, which was itself acquired by CSC Generation in September 2024.



SPECIALTY



The Brand House Collective (formerly **Kirkland's**) will open its first **Bed Bath & Beyond Home** store on August 8 in Nashville, TN, marking the return of the iconic brand less than two years after its bankruptcy closure. Brand House has also announced a ticker symbol change from KIRK to TBHC, effective July 29, 2025.



Ace Hardware has opened a new 472,000-square-foot retail support center in Lebanon, Indiana, creating more than 185 jobs. The facility will support over 350 Ace Hardware stores throughout the Midwest. Ace currently operates 17 retail support centers in the U.S. and has international distribution capabilities in Mexico, China, and Panama.



Martha Stewart has opened her first brick-and-mortar retail stores in partnership with Marquee Brands. The first two Martha Stewart stores opened in July at Woodbury Common Premium Outlets in New York and Clarksburg Premium Outlets in Maryland, with additional locations planned for later this year. The stores feature exclusive collections spanning bedding, bath, kitchen essentials, gardening tools, and seasonal home décor.



As reported in our July 24 [Alert](#), **Advance Auto Parts** announced a \$1.50 billion senior unsecured notes offering and plans for a new \$1 billion asset-based revolving credit facility. The Company will use the proceeds to redeem \$300 million of existing notes due in 2026 and for general corporate purposes. Advance also released preliminary Q2 financial results, with net sales expected to be between \$1.98 billion - \$2 billion, with comparable store sales growth of flat to +0.1%. CEO Shane O'Kelly stated the financing will "preserve financial flexibility" as the Company implements its turnaround strategy.



DRUG RETAILERS



In the **Rite Aid, DIP** case, the Debtors filed a motion on July 28, 2025, to close an additional 17 stores, bringing total store closings to 1,237 units. Separately, the Court issued an order authorizing the assumption and assignment of four leases in furtherance of a sale to CVS Pharmacy, Inc. The ruling covers some of the assets identified in the Debtors' previous motion to enforce a sale order and compel CVS to pay for assets it agreed to purchase. For more on this case, see our [Case Summary](#), last updated July 28.



RESTAURANTS



Chipotle Mexican Grill reported Q2 2025 total revenue increased 11.3% to \$2.9 billion and comparable restaurant sales rose 7.4%. Digital sales represented 35.5% of total food and beverage revenue. The Company opened 61 new restaurants during the quarter and reaffirmed its guidance of opening 315-345 new restaurants in fiscal 2025.



Wingstop is seeking to register the trademark "National Chicken Tender Day" with the U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. The move follows the Company's successful launch of chicken tenders in 2023, which now represent 15% of its sales mix. If approved, the trademark would give Wingstop exclusive rights to promote this food holiday, which would be celebrated on July 27.



BJ's Restaurants has named William J. Atkins as its interim principal financial officer, effective July 26. Atkins, who joined the Company in 2022 as chief information officer, will maintain both roles while a search continues for a permanent CFO. He previously held senior finance positions at Yum Brands and Taco Bell, bringing extensive restaurant industry experience to the position.



Shipley Do-Nuts has been sold by an affiliate of Peak Rock Capital to Levine Leichtman Capital Partners. The Houston-based chain, founded in 1936, has expanded to over 350 locations across 12 states. Under Peak Rock's ownership since 2021, Shipley implemented new technology platforms, entered new markets, and strengthened its franchisee relationships. Terms of the transaction were not disclosed.



Popup Bagels, which began as a home business during the pandemic, has reached agreements to open 300 stores across the U.S. over the next five years. The chain recently secured deals with existing franchisees to open 30 new locations, including its first in California. Popup Bagels currently has three corporate locations and operates in Connecticut, New York, and Massachusetts.



Yum Brands/KFC has appointed Tiffany Furman as chief growth officer, a newly created position focusing on brand growth and innovation. Furman, who previously served as the brand's U.S. chief marketing officer, will oversee marketing, menu innovation, and technology teams in her new role. The appointment is part of KFC's broader strategy to strengthen its leadership team and accelerate growth in the competitive quick-service restaurant market.



CONVENIENCE STORES



Wawa opened a new store in Garner, North Carolina on July 23, the chain's closest location to Raleigh yet. The Company also opened its first Indianapolis store on July 10 at 3835 E. 96th St., continuing its largest expansion in company history into new Midwest markets including Indiana, Ohio, and Kentucky.



Casey's General Stores released its annual report for fiscal year 2025 on July 24, detailing its expansion of 270 locations during the year. The Company plans to debut 80 new stores during fiscal 2026, which would exceed its current three-year goal of 500 openings.

This report is issued to the Subscriber for its exclusive use only and is compiled from sources which RetailStat, LLC ("RetailStat"), does not control and unless indicated is not verified. RetailStat, its principals, analysts, writers and agents do not guarantee the accuracy, completeness or timeliness of the information provided nor do they assume responsibility for the information reported herein nor for failure to report any matter omitted or withheld. This report and/or any part thereof may not be reproduced, and/or transmitted in any manner whatsoever. Any reproduction and/or transmission without the written consent of RetailStat is in violation of Federal and State Law.

